

Northern forest

In the cold north, the summers are so short that most deciduous trees cannot make enough food to survive. But evergreen conifer trees have tough leaves that make the most of every minute of daylight. These trees form the vast taiga, or boreal forests, that grow all around the globe just south of the northern polar regions.

THE BOREAL ZONE

The northern forests extend in a broad band through Scandinavia, northern Russia, Alaska, and Canada. They are very cold in winter, and have only around two frost-free months a year. There is not a lot of snowfall or rain, but the low temperatures mean that the ground never dries out.

▼ FROZEN FORESTS

Winter temperatures in the forest can drop below -58°F (-50°C) in parts of Siberia and Canada.

FROST-PROOF TREES

The waxy, needle-shaped leaves of conifer trees can survive months of freezing temperatures. Many tree species have a conical shape, which helps them shed heavy snow. They can also grow well on the acidic, infertile soils that are typical of these regions.



BOGGY GROUND

The cold ground beneath the forest trees is often waterlogged. This slows the normal processes of decay, creating thick layers of acidic peat dotted with bog pools. The peaty soil is colonized by spongy moss and acid-loving plants such as bilberry, blueberry, and red cranberry.